Frequently Asked Questions on the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL)

Updated as at 1 September 2026

Website FAQs

A. On the policy

A1: Which countries or regions can I hire from under the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL)?

Firms in the Manufacturing and Services sectors may hire Work Permit holders (WPHs) from the following countries under the NTS OL:

- Bangladesh
- Bhutan
- Cambodia
- India
- Laos
- Myanmar
- Philippines
- Sri Lanka
- Thailand

A2: How many Work Permits from Non-Traditional Sources (NTS) can I hire under the NTS Occupation List (NTS OL)?

Firms in the Manufacturing and Services sectors may hire NTS OL Work Permit holders up to 8% of their total workforce. Additionally, the firm must not exceed its sector's Dependency Ratio Ceiling (DRC).

Example:

NTS quota for a firm in the Manufacturing or Services sector already hiring 10 local workers and 2 Malaysian/NAS Work Permit holders = 8% x (total workforce [12] + 1) = 1 (rounded down to the nearest whole number)

Note:

Total workforce count

Total workforce count = Latest 3-month average number of local employees earning at least the local qualifying salary + Number of issued Work Permit holders + Number of issued S Pass holders.

Firms can check their current workforce profile data using WP Online.

Dependency Ratio Ceiling (DRC)

The overall DRC for:

- a Manufacturing firm is 60%
- a Services firm is 35%

For more details on calculating the number of Work Permit holders a firm can hire, refer to MOM's Quota Calculation Booklet.

A3: Can I pay my Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL) Work Permit holder a fixed monthly salary of less than $2,000?

No. All Work Permit holders on the NTS OL must be paid a fixed monthly salary of **at least** $2,000. Please cancel the Work Permit if you cannot meet this requirement.

A4: Why is the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL) not expanded to include more occupations?

The NTS OL enables firms in the Services and Manufacturing sectors to hire higher quality non-PMET workers from diverse sources, including those affected by the increase in the S Pass qualifying salary.

The occupations on the NTS OL were selected carefully in consultation with sector agencies and unions, taking into account the degree of local manpower shortages.

For each occupation added, there are trade-offs to local employment outcomes, infrastructural capacity and our social fabric, which we need to closely monitor. We will continue to review our Work Permit framework to enable firms to have access to higher quality workers from diverse sources to support productivity-driven growth.

B. On the eligibility criteria

B1: Why is the addition of heavy vehicle drivers onto the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL) restricted to NTS workers with valid heavy vehicle (Class 4 / 5) licence as of 1 September 2025?

The expansion of the NTS OL is to enable businesses to hire and retain higher-skilled workers who are affected by S Pass qualifying salary increases.

However, given the high demand for Class 4 and above licences, there is currently a long waiting time for Class 4 and above training lessons and testing slots. As such, for a start, we are extending the NTS OL only to heavy vehicle drivers who already hold Class 4 or 5 licences as of 1 September 2025. This will enable employers of existing NTS S Pass holders with valid Class 4 or 5 licences to retain them on a Work Permit if they do not meet the new S Pass qualifying salary from 1 September 2025.

When the backlog of training lessons and testing slots is cleared, we will work with Traffic Police to review this requirement.

B2: My company operates in the F&B industry and has a valid Singapore Food Agency (SFA) Food Shop Licence (or SFA Supermarket Licence). Why am I allowed to hire Food Services workers under the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL) but not food processing workers?

Food processing workers are involved in handling, preparing, and packaging various food products in central kitchens, food processing plants or factories which are issued with SFA licences to operate a food processing establishment or slaughterhouse.

Therefore, only firms with valid SFA licences to operate a food processing establishment or slaughterhouse are allowed to hire food processing workers.

B3: Why are firms with a valid SFA Supermarket licence allowed to hire NTS OL Food Services workers?

Firms with a valid SFA Supermarket licence are allowed to hire NTS OL Food Services workers as these businesses need such workers to handle and prepare food for their customers. The activities that such workers perform include specialised food handling and preparation services such as selling and preparing raw meat or seafood, or conducting on-site preparation of food for sale (e.g. at a rotisserie counter).

B4: What are the roles and responsibilities of the Early Childhood (EC)-related occupations (babysitter/infant care-giver, educarer and teacher aide) under the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL)?

The roles and responsibilities of these occupations are as follows:

Occupations	Roles and responsibilities
Babysitter/infant care-giver (also known as Infant Educator or Childminder)	Works with infants aged between 2 and 18 months old
Child/After school care centre worker (also known as Educarer or Early Years Educator or Educarer)	Works with young children aged between 2 months and 4 years old
Teacher aide (also known as Assistant Educator)	• Supports the Infant Educators and Early Years Educators in working with the young children • Assists in maintaining a safe and nurturing environment

Note: All occupations, except Teacher aide, require an Early Childhood Development Agency (ECDA)-recognised EC qualification.

For detailed descriptions on these occupations, please visit ECDA's website at www.ecda.gov.sg/shapeourtomorrow/how-to-be-an-educator.

C. On the application process

C1: Do I need to update MOM of my Singapore Food Agency (SFA) Food Shop or Supermarket licence to be eligible to hire butcher, fishmongers, and other related food preparers, food/drink stall assistants, kitchen assistants, and waiters under the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL)?
No, you do not need to update MOM about your SFA licence. We will verify this directly with SFA. However, if your firm has just recently obtained or renewed its SFA licence (for a food shop or supermarket), it may take time to update the licence information in our records. If you see a message in our eService while applying for a Work Permit under the NTS OL stating that MOM does not have a record of your SFA licence, you can submit a copy of your SFA licence for verification at go.gov.sg/sfa-licence-ntsol.

C2: Can my Work Permit holder hired under the Non-Traditional Sources Occupation List (NTS OL) in my Manufacturing or Services firm change their occupation?
Yes, but your worker must meet both conditions: • They can only change their occupation to those allowed on the NTS OL. • They must meet the current criteria. You need to submit a request using WP Online before they can change their occupation.